the west. Having just completed Exercise Poorna Vijay, where we had ample opportunity to streamline our procedures, we were able to mobilize faster than other offensive formations. Having reached our locations, we commenced recces of our respective areas and held operational discussions to fine-tune various plans and contingencies. Fortunately, we had made up a lot of our equipment deficiencies and put maximum number of tanks, guns and other equipment on road prior to our exercise. As most of my troops were under canvas, my caravan Chetak was my home for the next ten months.

We kept waiting for orders and the green signal but none came. However, we took our responsibility very seriously and carried out preparations for our mission as per the national strategy. Pakistan was taken aback by our alacrity and, in the early stages, was quite unprepared for a military showdown. On 12 January 2002, President Musharraf gave a speech in which he categorically stated that Pakistan would not allow its soil to be used for propagation of terrorism and attempted to defuse tension on the border. What that country actually did was something else. According to me, he used it as a clever ploy to buy time by saying the right things at a juncture when India could have gone in for some level of retaliatory military action. Musharraf did that once again by making a statement on 27 May 2002, which reiterated an assurance to end cross-border terrorism. This was soon after a cowardly attack by terrorists in a small military station near Jammu in which thirty-four people, most of them wives and children of army personnel, were killed. We were almost ready to go in once again by the first week of June, though by that time Pakistan was much better prepared compared to the opportunity we had in January 2002. A retributive military response has, in my view, a fleeting window of opportunity. Further, the international ramifications of an armed action have to be factored in before undertaking such a step. When provoked by a serious act of aggression or state-sponsored terrorism, the strike back has to be precise, short and swift.

However, the situation was defused this time too, perhaps due to international intervention, mainly by the US. Pakistan also resorted